now it's Mohan Gopal; Sam Pitroda provides inputs, so do Kanishka and Sachin Rao, and so does Priyanka. It all depends on the subject at hand,' was the best response I could get. It sounded a bit like a pig's breakfast!

Even Jairam, who could have played the lead role in Rahul's speech-writing team, appeared to be slowly edged out from the inner circle. I recall ringing him up and suggesting that we could do a youth-centric show with Rahul where he could take questions from IIT/IIM students. 'Good idea, will share it with Rahul,' Jairam told me. A few weeks later when I asked Jairam whether there was any progress, he simply shrugged his shoulders and pleaded helplessness. Rahul's one-time political 'guru' Digvijaya Singh's son-in-law, Paranjayadityasinh Parmar, scion of the royal family of Santrampur in Gujarat, who had been pushing for a ticket from Gujarat, was also struck off the final list. It was almost as if the spectre of looming defeat had pushed Rahul into a self-imposed cocoon of aloofness where he trusted very few people. 'We are told that leadership demands that when the going gets tough, the tough get going—here just the opposite was happening,' is how a Congress MP summed up Rahul's plight.

Senior journalist Coomi Kapoor relates a delightful story which perhaps exemplifies the widening gap between Rahul and the party. Apparently, Rahul had come to campaign in Devgarh Baria in the tribal-dominated Dahod constituency of southern Gujarat. The party candidate, Prabha Taviad, was prevented from sitting on the stage when Rahul was speaking by the SPG even though she tried to explain to them that she was, after all, the local Congress candidate. Rally over, Rahul shook a few hands and rushed to the helicopter. The candidate was desperate to have a word with her leader. *'Bhaag, Mummy, bhaag!'* her children implored her. She ran after Rahul, only to find that he was already sitting in the helicopter and on his way to another rally.

As the campaign wore on, it was obvious that Team Rahul was still groping in the dark for a big idea to counter the BJP. When Modi embarked on his Chai pe Charcha, they were again forced to react in an attempt to recapture at least the 'aam aadmi' space. Rahul had spoken of an 'open manifesto', one that would be shaped by interacting with Congress workers,